



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

ROMA WOMEN IN GOTHENBURG: NAVIGATING INTERNAL COMMUNITY NORMS AND INSTITUTIONAL BARRIERS

AN EXPLORATORY STUDY OF THE LIFE BETWEEN THE POLICY VOID OF EU FREE MOVEMENT AND INTERNAL COMMUNITY CONSTRAINTS

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Abstract

This thesis examines how Roma women who remain in Gothenburg beyond the three-month period of legal residence granted by EU freedom of movement rules experience and navigate their daily lives. The participants live between two polities. Romania holds their formal citizenship and, under the EU Roma Strategic Framework, the primary responsibility for their social inclusion. Sweden holds their daily governance, but the residence criterion places them outside welfare measures and outside of the national Roma Inclusion strategy. Drawing on five semi-structured interviews and reading the material through Nancy Fraser's three-dimensional theory of justice, the thesis shows that they employ deliberate economic strategies and hold a sense of dignity through their identities as mothers and providers, while depending on NGOs and the goodwill of individual Swedes rather than on any entitlement. Inside their community, they are only recognized as sacrificing mothers, and the asymmetry with their husbands gives this recognition a gendered dimension. In Swedish public space, the same activity is read as absence of work.

Applying Fraser's "all-subjected" principle, their position constitutes misframing, since they remain subject to Swedish governance without being included as subjects of justice in either community. The documented material and recognitive harms documented cannot be raised as claims within the existing frame. The major contribution is to bring this perspective into a debate that has rarely included it, and to read it through a framework that holds the economic, cultural, and political sides of their situation together.

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1. Introduction

Despite Sweden's longstanding commitment to welfare and minority rights, Roma people remain among the most economically excluded and socially marginalized groups in the country (Roma Civil Monitor, 2025). At the EU level, the Roma Strategic Framework for 2020-2030 provides the overarching policy orientation, addressing how ethnicity intersects with other aspects of identity and creates distinct experiences of discrimination. Within such an allocation, primary responsibility for the social inclusion of Roma populations rests with the member state of citizenship, and the Swedish national strategy operates as one expression of such division (European Commission, 2020; Regeringskansliet, 2012).

Following Romania's and Bulgaria's 2007 accession to the EU, a new population has emerged in Sweden: Romanian Roma exercising the right to free movement under Directive 2004/38/EC, but unable to meet the conditions for continued lawful residence beyond three months. Their presence is formally lawful, yet they are excluded from the standard welfare arrangements of either polity, and Swedish municipalities limit their obligations to emergency assistance.

This is the sub-population the Swedish policy debate refers to as “vulnerable EU citizens”. Such a denomination was coined in a 2016 Swedish Government Official Report to refer to individuals who are citizens of another EU member state but reside in Sweden without a permanent residence permit (Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017). The category consists almost entirely of Roma groups living in deep poverty (Friberg et al., 2025; Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017). Following Romania's and Bulgaria's accession to the EU in 2007, marginalization and exclusion from education and employment in their homelands drove increased migration to Sweden (Murt, 2021). Under *Directive 2004/38/EC*, EU citizens may reside in another member state for up to three months without conditions, after which they must have formal employment, be students, or have sufficient resources not to burden the social assistance system. The policy problem addressed concerns what happens after this period, when individuals cannot meet these requirements. For Roma migrants, the conditions for continued residence are nearly impossible to meet, since most lack sufficient resources and the informal activities many engage in, such as begging or collecting bottles, are not recognized as formal employment (Grundberg, 2016).

Their legal right to reside expires, but departure rarely occurs in practice (Friberg et al., 2025; Amnesty International, 2018). Many engage in circular migration to restart the three-month period, or remain without formal status, in a grey zone where their presence is tolerated but unregularized. The absence of formal employment forecloses residence rights, which in

turn closes off labor market integration programs, language training, and social support; the two conditions reinforce each other.

This population does not correspond to the standard categories through which migration is discussed. They are not migrants in the conventional sense, and they are not present in Sweden without authorization. They are citizens of the European Union, exercising the rights of free movement that this status carries. They cannot be deported on the grounds that would apply to a third-country national in an irregular position (Civil Rights Defenders, 2015). The responsibility for responding to their presence falls largely on municipalities, which interpret the Social Services Act narrowly and limit their obligations to emergency assistance, denying them entitlement to income support even when they remain for years (Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017). Ultimately, they are left with emergency aid and the help of civil society organizations only, as their residence formally stands in Romania (Thorisdottir, 2018).

Roma women in this context face an additional layer of marginalization. Ethnic discrimination is intensified by patriarchal norms within the family and by gendered expectations imposed by host-country institutions (Kóczé and Popa, 2009). A 2019 FRA report found that Roma women fare worse than both Roma men and women in the general population, with extreme poverty and discrimination intensifying in their case (FRA, 2019).

The structural exclusion of vulnerable EU citizens has been documented at the macro-level through analyses of legal frameworks and institutional designs, while the gendered dimensions of their hurdles have been examined in sociological work on Roma communities (Kóczé and Popa, 2009; Crowley et al., 2013). The two literatures have largely been kept apart, and there is a gap in documentation of how Roma women themselves interpret and navigate these constraints. To fill this gap, the study asks:

“How can the daily experiences and agency strategies of Roma women living in Gothenburg beyond the three-month residence limit be understood as claims for justice within the dimensions of redistribution, recognition, and representation?”

The study uses Nancy Fraser's (2005) three-dimensional theory of justice as analytical framework. Fraser (2005) argues that under contemporary conditions of globalization, the Keynesian-Westphalian frame, in which justice disputes were assumed to play out within territorial states among citizens, can no longer be presumed as the default unit within which justice claims are raised. The question of who counts as a subject of justice has itself become a question of justice. A framework able to address injustice must be three-dimensional, integrating representation into the existing distributive and recognitive dimensions. Within this political dimension, Fraser identifies a form of misrepresentation called misframing, which

arises when the boundaries of a community are drawn so as to exclude some people from the possibility of participating in its authorized contests over justice (Fraser, 2005).

The proposed remedy for determining subjects of justice is the “all-subjected principle”, which holds that all those jointly subject to a common governance structure have moral standing as subjects of justice in relation to it (Fraser, 2008). The thesis proceeds with this principle as its analytical lens; the discussion brings the empirical material and the policy context together through it. I used this framework solely as a tool to shed light on the women’s position. The thesis does not endorse the policy direction Fraser herself takes from it, as this goes beyond the aim of the study.

2. Previous Research

2.1. Roma Minority in Sweden: Historical Context and Minority Status

The Roma community is formally recognized as one of Sweden's five national minorities and has been in the country since the early sixteenth century, with approximately 100,000 individuals present today, the largest Roma population proportionally within the Nordic countries. This long presence has been marked by systematic persecution. Between 1934 and 1975, Sweden sterilized between 450 and 500 traveling Roma, affecting about one quarter of all traveling Roma households. State practices included child removals and registration systems that continued until the late twentieth century (Minority Rights Group, 2018; Roma Civil Monitor, 2020). In 1999, Romani Chib was recognized as a minority language under the European Charter for Regional or Minority Languages. The 2015 government White Paper acknowledged this as part of a broader "state culture of disdain" for the Roma minority, and in 2014 the Commission on Antiziganism was established to address discrimination (Minority Rights Group, 2018).

For the group the study concerns, this historical record matters because it shapes how they assess the risks of engaging with state institutions today. Studies on the Swedish context have shown that Roma women living in this position consistently reported fear of child removals and distrust of police (Aléx and Lehti, 2013; Iachim, 2019). Romania's accession to the EU in 2007 enabled increased Roma migration to Sweden and other member states. For many, the decision to move was driven by marginalization and systematic exclusion from employment. However, due to their lack of permanent residence, this segment of the population is excluded from Roma representative bodies such as the Council of Roma (Murt, 2021).

This study concerns the group of those who arrive under EU free movement rules and stay beyond the initial three months, either without formal status or through circular migration (Amnesty, 2018; Friberg et al., 2025). The most cited estimate, from 2015, places the number of EU citizens living in Sweden while begging at around 4,000 to 5,000, many of them Roma from Romania or Bulgaria (Barker, 2017; Grundberg, 2017). No more recent comprehensive figure is available, as there is no registration system that records this population (Amnesty International, 2018). Their presence generated unease in a country that had spent much of the twentieth century reducing poverty and strengthening the welfare system (Barker, 2017).

2.2. EU and Swedish Policy Frameworks for Roma Inclusion

The policy for Roma Inclusion operates at two main levels relevant to this study: the EU, which provides the overall framework, and the Member States, which hold primary responsibility for implementation.

The *EU Roma strategic framework for equality, inclusion and participation for 2020-2030* is the current overarching instrument (European Commission, 2020). It sets seven EU-level objectives, three horizontal (equality, inclusion, participation) and four sectoral (education, employment, housing, health), and asks Member States to develop national Roma strategic frameworks that translate them into measurable commitments by 2030. The Commission states that "Member States are key actors to enable change on the ground for Roma" and that "EU action and support will complement national efforts to promote progress towards the EU objectives and targets by 2030" (European Commission, 2020).

The 2020 framework added a focus on diversity within the Roma population, asking Member States to address the specific needs of groups such as Roma women, youth, children, EU mobile citizens, and older Roma in their national strategies (European Commission, 2020). This is the first time an EU instrument on Roma inclusion explicitly named EU mobile Roma citizens as a group whose situation Member States of residence are asked to address, separately from the inclusion measures owed to national minorities. Under this allocation, primary responsibility for the social inclusion of Romanian Roma rests with Romania. Romania has adopted successive national strategies in line with the EU framework, most recently the *2022-2027 Strategy for the Inclusion of Romanian Citizens Belonging to the Roma Minority*, which states that "the Romanian Government's strategy for the inclusion of Romanian citizens belonging to the Roma minority for the period 2015-2020 has only partially achieved its objectives" (Government of Romania, 2022, p. 11). The degree to which Romania meets its responsibilities under the framework determines whether the conditions that drive Roma migration are addressed at their source. A substantive assessment of this question lies beyond the scope of this thesis, which is concerned with Sweden.

Sweden established its national Roma strategy in 2012, aiming to ensure that a Roma child born in 2012 has the same life opportunities as a non-Roma child by 2032 (Regeringskansliet, 2012). The strategy is primarily directed at the Roma national minority. It does not formally differentiate by citizenship, but its implementation rests on a residence criterion that the participants cannot meet. The criterion is consistent with how the EU framework allocates responsibility: the social inclusion of Roma individuals is the responsibility, in the first instance, of the member state in which they hold citizenship.

2.3. The EU Three Month Rule and the Legal construction of the

“Vulnerable EU citizen”

The Treaty on the Functioning of the EU gives citizens the right to move and reside in any EU country, but *Directive 2004/38/EC* limits this freedom to three months without condition. After that, EU law sets specific criteria for continued residency, such as having a job or actively looking for one, being a student, or possessing adequate resources for self-support and a health insurance (Grundberg, 2016; Civil Rights Defenders, 2015). There is not registration system upon entry, so authorities do not systematically know who has the right to reside or should leave, and there is no established practice to expel those who lack the right; many leave and re-enter to restart the three-month clock (Amnesty, 2018).

The target of this study, those who remain beyond the permitted timeline, cannot meet the requirements for extended residence. Earning money through informal activities such as begging or collecting bottles is not considered work and does not count towards a residence permit. They are not deported, and their continued stay is formally legal if they engage in circular migration, as it is most commonly the case. Notwithstanding, they operate outside the formal labor market and lack access to social rights and pathways to residence (Amnesty, 2018).

The term “vulnerable EU citizen” was coined in a 2016 Swedish Government Official Report to refer to “individuals who are citizens of another EU country and do not have a Swedish residence permit” (Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017, p. 25). The treatment of this group is not governed by unified regulations; there is no established practice as to how Swedish municipalities should prevent social exclusion among those who are not Swedish citizens (Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017). The category carries an ethnic implication that goes beyond technical wording. It consists almost entirely of Roma in deep poverty, partially concealing the history of antiziganism that systematically excluded them from employment and education in their countries of origin (Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017).

According to the Swedish Association of Local Authorities and Regions (SALAR), a municipality has responsibility for responding to acute situations and for emergency assistance to non-citizen residents, with no right to income support or extended welfare (Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017). Since EU regulations limit Member States’ ability to restrict free movement, and EU migrants only acquire rights through formal employment, access to standard welfare services remains unrealistic (Friberg et al., 2025). The lack of a shared view among authorities makes protection dependent on local policies, creating geographical fragmentation.

Municipalities increasingly choosing to evict EU citizens and prevent informal settlements (Friberg et al., 2025).

The specificity of the Swedish case is part of what produced this population. Begging is not prohibited under Swedish law and is not banned or subject to licensing at the national level (Amnesty International, 2018). Sweden's response to the post-2007 arrival of vulnerable EU citizens has combined this non-prohibition with municipal evictions of informal settlements, a configuration Barker (2017) reads as the product of dualities internal to the Nordic welfare state. The universalist welfare arrangement that historically gave little visibility to street poverty in Sweden does not extend to those outside formal residence.

Friberg et al. (2025) describe vulnerable EU citizens in Scandinavia as a population whose presence is “not formally challenged” but who “effectively lack access to social rights and pathways to residence” because they operate outside the formal labor market (Friberg et al., 2025, p. 275). Borevi (2023) characterizes this position as a dual insider/outsider status, in which marginalized intra-EU migrants are insiders by virtue of free movement rights and outsiders because of their lack of access to social rights or permanent residence (as discussed in Friberg et al., 2025).

The result is a setting in which a population is present in public spaces lawfully and continuously, governed in fact by Swedish institutions, but located outside the redistributive arrangement that defines Swedish political membership.

2.4. Roma Women's Sociocultural and Structural Barriers

For Roma women, the external exclusion determined by their standing as “vulnerable EU citizens” intersects with constraints within the community, leading to a qualitatively different form of marginalization that part of the existing policy literature largely overlooks. According to a 2019 report by the European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights, Roma women face “additional challenges as extreme poverty, exclusion and discrimination”, and “continue to fare worse than Roma men and than women in the general population” (FRA, 2019, p. 3).

Being one of the most deprived groups in Europe, they are excluded both as women and as members of Europe's largest ethnic minority (Salazar-Saenz and Robayo-Abril, 2020). The literature links this to patriarchal structures within Roma communities, where traditional roles condition women and girls' freedom of choice in fundamental life decisions. They often occupy a subordinate role within families and communities, which can limit personal will and lead to higher rates of domestic violence. Their educational level is consistently lower than that of both Roma men and non-Roma women, a result of discrimination and early marriage and

motherhood (Crowley et al., 2013). These internal dynamics are reinforced by long-standing stereotypes that shape how they are perceived in wider society.

Talpa (2014) traces the symbolic dimensions of stigma to enduring European imagery, arguing that the presence of Roma women in public spaces has always been controversial. The most common depictions fall into two contrasting categories: a humble, obedient wife with no power to make decisions, or a witch who breaks rules and social conventions. The stereotype of the "gypsy witch" has been the most widespread in Romanian folklore, and still affects their current image, leading to differential treatment in education, employment, and encounters with authorities (Talpa, 2014).

Besides the conditions internal to Roma communities, research has examined how Roma migrant women are perceived by state actors in host countries. Maestri and Mantovan (2025), in an intersectional study of Romanian Roma migrants in Italy, found that public authorities apply patriarchal and orientalist gender stereotypes that depict Roma mothers as solely responsible for childcare and particularly dysfunctional and in need of re-education. Their research also showed that Roma migrant women tend to organize their economic activities around their domestic role as mothers and wives, while Roma men's visibility in public space operates differently. Their presence in host societies is consistently read through a maternal lens, namely a gendered framing that shapes how institutions perceive them and how their economic activity is legible (Maestri and Mantovan, 2025).

2.5. Roma Women in Sweden

Despite growing attention to Roma inclusion in Sweden, empirical research on Roma women's lived experiences remains limited. Three studies are particularly close to my research.

Iacob (2017) examined the implementation of Roma inclusion strategies in Malmö through interviews with policymakers and civil society representatives, as direct interviews with Roma women were not possible. Staff at the Roma Information and Knowledge Centre described the women as generally absent from the public sphere and with limited access to information about their rights, voicing concerns within community boundaries rather than to municipal institutions. Contact with authorities was marked by distrust and prejudiced attitudes. The women were described as bound by stereotyped social roles, with girls facing different household expectations than boys. Aspirations were nevertheless high, and the women hoped their children would access university and secure stable employment.

Aléx and Lehti (2013) interviewed Finnish-speaking Roma women in northern Sweden, citizens covered by minority protection. Participants described a hierarchical family structure in which “men are on top, women below” and expressed fear of authorities, particularly around child removals, which they interpreted as a strategy to erase Roma culture. None of them was

formally employed. Reading the data through Bourdieu's framework, the authors argue that the absence of economic capital made these women subordinate to family hierarchies and to Swedish society alike, with material deprivation and misrecognition reinforcing each other (Al  x and Lehti, 2013).

Neither Iacob (2017) nor Al  x and Lehti (2013) addressed the group of recently arrived Roma women who lack legal status and minority recognition and rely on begging for survival. Iachim (2019) interviewed five women in this category in Malm   and found victimization at levels above those reported in studies of more integrated populations, including verbal abuse, sexual harassment, physical assault, and complete distrust of police. Internal community constraints did not loosen under external pressure. Traditional clothing made the women more visible to perpetrators, yet changing dress risked strong reactions from Roma men. Internal expectations continued to shape the women's decisions even when their safety was at stake.

Iachim's (2019) study reached the population of vulnerable EU citizens but read them through a frame of victimization. Recording the verbal abuse and harassment these women had faced confirmed that they were harmed, but left out the agency they exercised in navigating their daily lives, their economic strategies, the way they make sense of their own work, and the relationships they built in the host country.

For a population whose presence is already read by Swedish institutions and public discourse through narratives of helplessness or burden, an account that adds another layer of vulnerability without showing how the women themselves navigate it confirms the framing that produced their exclusion in the first place.

This thesis took the women's own interpretation of their situation as its starting point, asking how they navigated their conditions before asking what was done to them.

2.6. Theoretical Approaches to Roma Women's Marginalization

Early policy-driven research on Roma paid virtually no attention to how gender, ethnicity, and poverty intertwine. This is attributed to the absence of gender-disaggregated data and to a tendency within Roma scholarship to treat the community as internally homogeneous, with gender often considered as an isolated category rather than a social factor that interacts with other social categories (Cukrowska and K  cz  , 2013).

K  cz  's (2011) work develops this critique into a substantive argument about how Roma women's marginalization should be theorized. She begins from observing that Roma women have remained largely absent from political, social, and academic discourse. Historical and anthropological scholarship has examined their place within traditional communities, but the

socioeconomic dimensions of their livelihood and their leadership in civil society organizations remain largely unexplored (Kóczé, 2011).

Kóczé builds on Stuart Hall's argument that race is the modality in which class is lived to show that economic marginalization and racial stigma operate together for Roma individuals (Kóczé, 2011). Anti-gypsyism, in her account, has framed Roma as Europe's most unwanted group since 1989. The two reinforce one another in a cycle of deprivation that neither dimension on its own can explain.

Gender, she argues, is equally critical. Feminist scholarship has begun to treat these categories as mutually constituting, but studies that examine gender, race, and class together remain scarce (Kóczé and Popa, 2009). Drawing on her empirical work with Romani women activists in Cluj, Romania, she argues that race, gender, and class must be observed together in any analysis of Roma women's situation.

This account explains why Roma women are marginalized along several axes, and her argument applies to the population this thesis studies. The intersectional tradition Kóczé builds on was originally developed for a different problem. Crenshaw (1991) introduced the concept by analyzing how Black women in the United States were failed by antidiscrimination law that recognized either race or gender but not both, in cases such as *DeGraffenreid v. General Motors*. Yuval-Davis (2011) later extended this work to citizenship and argued that the categories of membership themselves are stratified along racial and gendered lines.

Both authors consider a population who already holds legal standing in the polity and asks how that community's categories fail them. The women in this study are placed differently. They are vulnerable EU citizens who fall outside Swedish welfare and outside the Swedish Roma inclusion strategy, despite living under Swedish governance.

3. Theoretical Framework

The thesis draws on Nancy Fraser's three-dimensional theory of justice as the analytical lens through which the situation of the women interviewed is read (Fraser and Honneth, 2003; Fraser, 2005). The framework is used here for its focus on cases in which economic, cultural and political conditions of disadvantage operate together. It is not a position the thesis defends, and the following analysis is concerned with the diagnostic work the framework can do rather than with the normative direction Fraser takes from it.

The starting point in *Redistribution or Recognition?* (Fraser and Honneth, 2003) is that maldistribution and misrecognition are two analytically distinct forms of injustice that nevertheless cut across the same real-world axes of subordination (Fraser and Honneth, 2003). Maldistribution is rooted in the economic structure of society and remedied through redistribution. Misrecognition stems from the institutionalized patterns of cultural value that govern who counts as a full partner in social interactions; it is remedied through a change in those patterns (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, pp. 13–14). The two dimensions are irreducible to one another, since the economic structure and the status order operate independently from each other in modern capitalist society. Neither form of injustice can be derived from, or resolved by addressing, the other alone (Fraser and Honneth, 2003).

In some cases, the dimensions converge in groups defined as “two-dimensional”. These individuals suffer from a subordination rooted simultaneously in the economic structure and the status order. The two harms are primary and co-original, and neither redistribution nor recognition on its own is sufficient to resolve the injustice (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 19). Gender and race are the paradigm cases. Gender, on the economic side, structures the division between paid productive labour and unpaid reproductive and domestic labour, and within paid labour the division between higher-paid male-dominated occupations and lower-paid female-dominated ones. On the side of status, it operates through androcentrism, an institutionalized pattern of cultural value that privileges traits coded as masculine and devalues those coded as feminine (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, pp. 20–21). “Race” operates along the same two dimensions, dividing higher-paid from exploited and racialized labour on the economic side and operating through Eurocentric value patterns that favor whiteness on the side of status (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, pp. 23–24). In each case, “virtually all axes of subordination partake simultaneously of the status order and the class structure, albeit in different proportions” (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 49); addressing one dimension alone leaves the other in place.

The normative principle Fraser uses to evaluate both dimensions is participatory parity. According to it, justice requires social arrangements that permit all members of society to

interact with one another as peers, and the two conditions for such parity are that the distribution of material resources ensures participants' independence and “voice” and that institutionalized patterns of cultural value not constitute some actors as inferior or simply invisible, thereby as less than full partners in social interaction (Fraser and Honneth, 2003). Maldistribution and misrecognition are the two structural conditions under which participatory parity fails.

In *Reframing Justice in a Globalizing World* (2005), Fraser adds a third dimension. The Keynesian-Westphalian frame, in which justice disputes were assumed to play out within territorial states among citizens, has been destabilized by the conditions of globalization; the question of who counts as a subject of justice has become contestable in ways that earlier theories of justice did not need to address (Fraser, 2005). A framework adequate to these conditions must therefore be three-dimensional, incorporating the political dimension of representation together with the economic dimension of distribution and the cultural dimension of recognition. Within the political dimension, a deeper form of misrepresentation called “misframing” exists. It arises when the boundaries of a community are drawn in a way that excludes some people from the possibility of participating in its authorized contests over justice (Fraser, 2005). The exclusion is a meta-injustice in the sense that it places the maldistribution and misrecognition the excluded suffer beyond the reach of the political community within which such claims could be raised.

In *Scales of Justice* (2008), Fraser develops the criterion for assigning standing as a subject of justice. She proposes the all-subjected principle, according to which all those who are subjected to a given governance structure have standing as subjects of justice in relation to it, regardless of whether they hold formal political membership (Fraser, 2008). This principle provides the analytical basis on which the political dimension is examined in the discussion. It is used as a heuristic to show the discrepancy between the conditions of governance of the participants and the frame within which they currently have standing to raise claims.

The political dimension carries its own normative principle. There are at least three candidate principles for determining who counts as a subject of justice (Fraser, 2008). The *membership principle* ties standing to formal citizenship, which on her account shields exclusionary nationalism from external critique. The *humanist principle* ties standing to common humanity, but it locates the question at a level of abstraction that names no specific social relation between claimants and any governance structure. The *all-affected principle* ties standing to causal effect, but under conditions of globalization it loses discriminating force, since nearly any action affects nearly everyone. She rejects each in turn, establishing the all-subjected principle, on which standing as a subject of justice tracks subjection to a governance structure, with no requirement of formal residence or citizenship (Fraser, 2008).

The three dimensions enter the analysis differently. Redistribution and recognition operate as coding categories for the interview material, where they are used to organize what the participants describe. Representation is not used as a coding category, since the question it raises, whether the political community within which the participants' claims could be raised includes them, is not a question the interview material on its own can settle. It is assessed in the discussion chapter, where misframing and the all-subjected principle read jointly the legal and policy material and the empirical material.

4. Main Contributions

In Sweden, vulnerable EU citizens have been a recurring subject of public debate over the past decade, with little consideration of their own interpretations. Two bodies of literature have primarily informed this debate.

The legal-institutional scholarship has documented how the residence conditions of EU free movement law, combined with the residence-based criteria of Swedish welfare regulation, produce a population that is present in Sweden lawfully but it excluded from welfare access beyond emergency provision under the Social Services Act, while also lacking effective access to support in Romania (Friberg et al., 2025; Giritly Nygren and Nyhlén, 2017; Thorisdottir, 2018).

The sociological work on Roma women in Europe has documented the cultural and gendered patterns through which their public presence is read in receiving societies (Kóczé and Popa, 2009; Crowley et al., 2013; Maestri and Mantovan, 2025). Each has done substantive work in its own register, but the two have been pursued in parallel, and the women themselves appear in neither as the source of the account.

The thesis is exploratory in nature, and its contributions are situated at the intersection of these two literatures. The main contribution is to read the two strands together through the accounts of women who live them at once, organizing the analysis around Fraser's three-dimension theory of justice.

The theoretical contribution is to apply the all-subjected principle, introduced in section 3, as a diagnostic lens on a population whose subjection to Swedish governance is continuous but whose formal political membership and right to Roma inclusion measures are held by Romania, where they are also not reached in practice.

The empirical contribution is to document the women's accounts of their own agency in areas the existing literature has not addressed. I documented the way they describe their economic activity as work and as care for the family, the comparison they drew between life in Sweden and Romania, and the maternal standing that organizes their standing both inside the community of origin and in the broader Swedish society.

Regarding policy, the reading provides an opening into how the policy debate has been framed. In Sweden, the question of what to do about this population has tended to be posed as a choice between extending welfare entitlement to all EU citizens regardless of residence and treating the population as a problem of migration control. The legal and policy material brought into chapter 9 indicate that the EU framework already contains instruments that respond to the configuration described.

5. Overarching Research question

“How can the daily experiences and agency strategies of Roma women living in Gothenburg beyond the three-month residence limit be understood as claims for justice within the dimensions of redistribution, recognition, and representation?”

6. Methodology

This study employs a qualitative research design that draws on two kinds of material. The first is a set of semi-structured interviews with five women who self-identify as Roma and sleep at an accommodation provided by the NGO Räddningsmissionen. The second is the body of EU and Swedish policy documents that defines their legal position, namely Directive 2004/38/EC, the EU Roma Strategic Framework, the 2021 Council Recommendation on Roma equality, inclusion and participation, and Sweden's 2012 national Roma inclusion strategy.

The interviews supply data on the dimensions the participants navigate in daily life—redistribution and recognition. The political dimension of representation cannot be derived from interview data alone, since it concerns the legal and institutional architecture within which the participants are placed rather than the conditions they describe from inside that architecture. The policy material establishes the frame within which the redistributive and recognitive claims contained in the women's situation can or cannot be raised. The discussion brings the two together.

The use of a qualitative method follows from the research question itself, as it asks how participants themselves experience and navigate their situation. A survey instrument could not have been used for a population that is mostly illiterate, and official statistics would have only documented their structural condition.

I recruited the participants through my prior voluntary work in a social center they attend, where I spent several months assisting with daily activities and getting to know the women. This long-term presence helped establish a relationship of trust, which facilitated access and made it possible to discuss sensitive topics. All names appearing in the thesis are pseudonyms, and any sensible information regarding the participants' personal conditions has not been inserted.

I divided the interview guide into thematic sections: “demographic and family background”; “earning money and material resources”; and “access to services and encounters with authorities and civil society” (see Appendix for the full questionnaire). All interviews took place in a quiet room at the social center, lasted between forty and sixty minutes, and were conducted in Romanian, English, or Italian. In two cases a Romanian-speaking social worker from the NGO interpreted live. I took handwritten notes and recorded all interviews after receiving explicit consent.

Given the vulnerability of the participants and the sensitivity of the topics, I strictly followed ethical principles at every stage. I obtained informed consent orally before each interview, explaining that participation was voluntary and could be withdrawn at any time. As all participants had limited literacy, I read the consent form aloud in Romanian. I deleted audio recordings after transcription, and made handwritten notes only accessible to me. The presence

of a familiar social worker as interpreter helped ensure that women felt at ease and free to refuse any question. I did not offer any financial or material incentives, and made sure to the participants that I would have used the information provided only for educational purposes.

When analyzing the material, I followed the systematic procedure for qualitative data analysis outlined by Miles et al. (2014), which proceeds through iterative cycles of data condensation, data display, and conclusion drawing. I first converted handwritten notes and audio recordings into verbatim transcripts. This conversion also allowed to add back contextual details such as hesitations and body language. The analysis proceeded through two cycles of coding. In the first cycle, I inductively assigned short codes to meaningful segments of text, ranging from a single sentence to a short paragraph. A code captures the primary content of a passage and serves as the critical link between raw data and the development of broader themes (Miles et al., 2014). The aim at this stage was to stay close to the women's accounts before introducing theoretical structuring. I employed three of the code types described by the authors. Descriptive codes summarize the topic of a passage (e.g. "Sending remittances" for a passage in which participants described sending money monthly to her children). Emotional codes label feelings recalled or inferred (e.g. "Pride as woman/worker/provider" for accounts of feeling useful by funding their children's education). Values codes capture attitudes, beliefs, and moral commitments (e.g. "Faith as moral compass" for testimonies of religion as a guiding principle). Some codes belonged to more than one category; the combinations are recorded in the Appendix (Table 5) using the markers D, E, and V.

I then moved to second-cycle or pattern coding, which Miles et al. (2014) describe as the grouping of first-cycle summaries into a smaller number of themes. I clustered the first-cycle codes along two intersecting criteria. First, I sorted them by theoretical category: codes referring to economic conditions, material resources, work, and income were grouped under redistribution; codes referring to identity, status, dignity, and interpersonal treatment were grouped under recognition. Second, within each category, I noticed the women's accounts consistently distinguished between assertions of agency and experiences of constraint. This yielded four pattern codes: "Navigating economic survival" and "Barriers to economic participation" within redistribution, and "Asserting dignity and agency" and "Experiences of stigmatization and constraint" within recognition.

The mapping between first-cycle codes and Fraser's dimensions involved interpretative work, since Fraser does not name the specific phenomena the women described. Her account of misrecognition concerns institutionalized patterns of cultural value that deny some people standing as full partners in social interactions (Fraser and Honneth, 2003), but does not specify what those patterns look like in street-level encounters. Reading "verbal abuse from the public" as misrecognition involved my judgement that such abuse is not isolated behavior but an expression of a wider cultural pattern denying the women standing in the public sphere. A

similar judgement constitutes the redistributive coding: “Active use of NGOs” was read as a marker of the institutional gap left by the Swedish welfare state, and “Sending remittances” as a marker of exclusion from the redistributive arrangement that would normally allow the women to support their families through formal work. Following Miles et al.'s (2014) recommendation that initial coding frames should be treated as provisional, I added new codes when the data revealed themes not anticipated by the theory. The most significant of these became a fifth pattern code, “Suppression in Romania”, which emerged from the consistency with which participants referred to the conditions they had faced in their country of origin. Although the study examines their situation in Sweden, this addition enriches the analysis, since the women are still formally residents of Romania and their perceptions are shaped by a comparative baseline of hardship at home.

The empirical analysis is organized under two headings, “Redistribution” and “Recognition” (Fraser and Honneth, 2003), since economic survival and social status are immediate daily experiences. Table 1 presents the inductive first-cycle codes that emerged under each heading from the interview material on the participants' current life in Sweden; Table 2 presents the deductive coding structure applied to the participants' accounts of the conditions they left behind in Romania.

Representation and misframing are reserved for the discussion, as they describe a structural condition produced by the interaction of Romanian, Swedish, and EU jurisdictions, and so concern what the participants are subject to rather than what they navigate in daily action. This ordering preserves a clear distinction between their personal agency and the institutional architecture that governs their presence in Gothenburg.

In accordance with the department's guidelines on artificial intelligence in student work, I declare that Claude and Gemini were used during the writing of this thesis as editing assistants. I used them for grammar and language revision, and for support during the coding stage of the interview material, where they helped sort first-cycle codes into pattern themes for the analysis. All the analytical work, theoretical interpretations, and the wording of the final text are my own. The AI did not generate any empirical material and did not contribute to the formulation of the argument. I reviewed and restructured all text before implementing it.

7. Empirical Findings

7.1 Redistribution

7.1.1 Navigating Economic Survival

All five participants linked their economic activities in Sweden to supporting children and grandchildren in Romania. Camelia stated directly: "I am here for my children and to make their lives better." Mirela captured the shared motivation symbolically: "If you ask all of us ladies why we moved to Sweden, we will all give the same answer: to make money for our children." Doina added that she had decided to come because she wanted to make money to take better care of her children and pay for utilities in Romania.

The women distinguished between two kinds of income-generating activity, and highlighted a relevant difference between them. Those who sold self-published books described this as dignified work. Elena stated: "My work is to sell books to people. I do not beg. I don't like to sit down." Mirela, who engaged in both activities, drew a sharp distinction: "Begging is no work; it is only sad. I do not like it, but I need it because I do not have any other situation."

All five women relied on material support from the NGO Räddningsmissionen, while none reported receiving regular assistance from Swedish social services. Doina explained, "Every time I need any other kind of support I come to the NGO and ask them for anything." Mirela, who had slept on the streets for seven years before accessing the shelter, said: "Now we feel safer because we have somewhere to sleep."

In all accounts, the NGO was the first point of contact for material needs that would in other circumstances fall to municipal welfare provision. No participant described a Swedish state institution in this role, and the healthcare they received was likewise accessed through the NGO.

All participants sent the money they made to Romania. Mirela stated: "All the money I make, I give to my children in Romania." Doina described the allocation: "If I make 200 SEK, I keep 100 for me to buy food and cigarettes and I send 100 to Romania."

Daily earnings were low and unstable. Camelia and Maria both reported earning thirty to fifty SEK per day, while Doina earned around two hundred SEK per day and noted that this was insufficient to cover both survival in Sweden and support for family back home.

7.1.2 Barriers to Economic Participation

Formal employment was out of reach for all participants. They were, in all accounts, able to point to the barriers preventing it, and showed high awareness of their limits. Four participants named lack of language knowledge as a decisive obstacle. Maria explained: "I really wish I could work here, for example take care of older ladies, clean houses, in hotels, but I cannot because I don't speak English or Swedish." Illiteracy extended the barriers for two of them, with Elena stating: "I would really like to learn how to read and write and learn some Swedish, otherwise I cannot do almost anything.". Doina echoed this: "If only I could speak English or Swedish, I would certainly look for a job and I would work".

Legal status constituted a barrier for two participants. Mirela explained: "I cannot do other jobs and I cannot stay here permanently; I have my children in Romania." Elena similarly described having to travel back and forth from Romania to Sweden to maintain her right to stay.

7.2 Recognition

7.2.1 Asserting Dignity and Agency

All five women expressed pride in being a woman, tied to their roles as mothers and providers. Doina asked rhetorically: "How can you not be proud to be a woman? I am proud because I have children and grandchildren." Maria added: "I am proud because many people treat me badly and tell me to go to work, but I still resist and I am strong.". The shared formulation matters for what follows. Pride is anchored in endurance and sacrifice for others, not in self-worth on the women's own terms; this anchoring shapes how they understand their economic activity.

Two women also drew on religion as a source of inner strength. Maria recounted giving her last twenty crowns to a young woman who had asked for money for her daughter, adding: "God is always observing and listening, and he knows I am a good person." Mirela said: "I always trust God because he has a plan and he is good."

All participants exercised agency in deciding, alone or jointly with a partner. Four said the decision was theirs alone, while Mirela noted: "My husband and I decided together that I should come to Sweden." They also reported significant voice in family decisions. Elena stated: "When there is something important, especially regarding our children, we make decisions

together." Mirela was the most emphatic: "I feel like I have power. I tell you honest, I am power."

Encounters with Swedish healthcare providers were consistently described as respectful¹. Maria explained: "When I go to the doctor, they always treat me with respect, and I do not think there is a difference in treatment between me and a Swedish person." She contrasted this with Romania: "Doctors here are way better than in Romania; they talk very well and treat me with respect." Elena confirmed the same: "I needed to see a doctor and it was very nice. He treated me very well."

The women also described positive encounters with Swedish police officers. Almost all participants distinguished between police and security guards, speaking of the former as respectful. Elena stated: "I feel like the police treat me with much respect," and Mirela said: "the police never treat me badly." She recalled an incident several years earlier when she was detained briefly after taking food because she was hungry, but described this as an isolated episode in an otherwise positive overall experience. Doina even stated that some police officers were her friends and that she felt safer knowing they were on the street.

The women referred to these long-standing interactions as long-lasting friendships, and did not speak of them as charity.

Mirela affirmed she had "many Swedish girls that are so sweet and always help me", adding that they stayed in contact through a WhatsApp group. Maria said there are many Swedish people who, after years of knowing her, "yell my name and come hug me" when they see her. Elena valued the fact that, even when people did not buy her books, they stopped to hear about how Roma live in Romania. Camelia expressed direct gratitude to the country and the people living in it for the help she has received

¹ The doctor service the participants describe is itself provided through a collaboration. Between Räddningsmissionen and "Närhälsan vårdcentral hemlösa" (Health Center for the Homeless), and not through the regional healthcare authority. The health center supports those who do not possess a permanent health center contact (<https://www.narhalsan.se/varldcentral/riktade-mottagningar/varldcentral-hemlosa/>)

7.2.2 Stigmatization and Constraint

Verbal abuse from members of the public was a common occurrence for all participants. Elena reported: "Sometimes people do not treat me with respect and tell me to go to work or go back to my country." Maria stated, "You have no idea how many 'slaps' I get here", clarifying that she meant this figuratively as a form of verbal abuse. Mirela reported the same pattern: "Often they ask me why I do not go to work and why I am here begging.". Doina added that "it happens sometimes that they don't treat me well and say bad words."

Where women distinguished between police and security guards, the latter were consistently reported as aggressive. Elena stated: "The guards at the mall are really bad. They are very aggressive." She described an incident in which guards forbid the women from entering for twenty-four hours, then expelled them again on return even when they were not selling books. Maria, who did not distinguish between police and guards, said: "The police always tell me 'go, go, go'." The content of these abuses was similar in the accounts, and all women reported being told repeatedly to work or leave the country. The verbal abuse expresses a wider pattern: the women's presence in public space is read as unwillingness to work and as foreignness.

All women handled all the household and childcare labour alone in Romania, with husbands contributing little or nothing. Elena said: "In Romania, I was the only one taking care of the house and cleaning and he does not do anything, but I like doing it." Doina explained: "When I was home in Romania, I used to do every housework: make food for the children, take them to school, help them with homework, take them everywhere, also my grandchildren." Maria's situation offered a counterexample to the patterns of agency described above. She stated: "There are some things I cannot do because my husband says no, like some family decisions".

Besides this asymmetry in housework, a parallel imbalance emerged in the provision of income. In four of the five cases, the husbands did not work, and the women were the ones earning for the family. Maria described her husband as "very sick at the moment" and unable to support her. Doina spoke of her husband in Romania and described herself as the only one earning. Mirela was the exception, as she described her husband as also generating income, travelling to Denmark to collect bottles or sell newspapers when more money was needed. All participants conceptualized their migration as necessary for the survival of the family, with no corresponding expectation placed on their husbands, who were in some cases described as enjoying more freedom in Romania

7.3 Suppression in Romania

All the participants spoke at length about the conditions they had faced in Romania, characterized by material deprivation and ethnic discrimination. Camelia stated: "I wish I could go back to Romania, but I would earn so little that I could not even buy diapers for children." Doina described the inadequacy of state support, noting that child allowance and social assistance together amounted to roughly five hundred SEK per month, insufficient even for diapers and milk.

Beyond material hardship, the women described systematic exclusion based on their Roma identity. Doina stated: "In Romania, nobody can hire me because I cannot read and because I am a gypsy. They do not like us." Mirela also highlighted this: "In my hometown, they treat me differently because I am Roma". Romania served as the comparative baseline for the women's interpretation of their circumstances in Sweden. Doina captured the contrast directly: "In Romania they treat me differently because I am a gypsy. In Sweden this does not happen." Camelia said, "In Sweden I do not feel treated differently because I am gypsy and they respect me a lot, no one gives me problems."

8. Discussion

8.1 Main Findings and Answer to the Research Question

The research question asked how the daily experiences and agency strategies of Roma women living in Gothenburg beyond the three-month limit allowed by Directive 2004/28/EC can be understood as claims for justice within the dimensions of redistribution, recognition and representation. Fraser's framework makes this reading possible because, on her account, injustice is a property of institutionalized social arrangements rather than a property of individual experience or perception (Fraser and Honneth, 2003). A claim for justice can be present in someone's life even when that person does not name their situation as unjust, provided the institutional arrangements they live under fail the standard of participatory parity. They endure harsh conditions to support their families, and describe their life in Sweden positively against the comparative baseline of Romania. Reading the interview material through this lens allows the analysis to identify the claims the situation contains, independently of whether the participants make them explicit themselves. The framework's diagnostic role is to make visible structural conditions that those subjected to them have not necessarily had the resources to name.

The participants are citizens of one EU member state, Romania, residing in another, Sweden, beyond the three-month period set by Directive 2004/38/EC. Their daily life is governed by Swedish laws and services. Their formal citizenship is held by Romania; neither polity includes them as subjects of justice in relation to itself.

The Roma inclusion strategy and the welfare regime that would otherwise address their ethnic and material conditions both rest on a residence criterion they cannot meet. Fraser (2005) treats this kind of mismatch as the prior condition that prevents claims for redistribution and recognition from being raised within the community whose governance the excluded nonetheless live under

8.2 Redistribution

The NGO Rådningsmissionen featured consistently in all accounts as the primary source of material support, covering shelter, medicine provision, clothing, and bureaucratic assistance. None of the women reported receiving regular assistance from Swedish social services. The NGO occupied the space that state provision left empty, and its support was described as reliable and dignified. Daily earnings were low and unstable, and all participants sent the money they made to Romania and kept their own consumption in Sweden to a minimum to keep providing for their families. Formal employment was out of reach for all of them, who were able to point precisely to the barriers preventing it. The economic activity the women performed in Sweden was therefore not a chosen alternative to formal labor, but the only form of income available under their constraints, as all of them expressed the desire to find a more stable job.

Maldistribution lies in the economic structure that positions some actors as participants in the productive order and others outside of it (Fraser and Honneth, 2003). The diagnosis is deeper than the quantity of resources a person receives, because it concerns the standing of the person in relation to the order through which resources are produced and distributed.

The participants occupy a structurally excluded position within the Swedish redistributive order. Although their economic activity takes place in Sweden and sustains families in Romania, it does not grant access to formal employment, welfare entitlement, or residence security. Material support therefore arrives primarily through NGOs and private individuals rather than through institutional membership in the welfare system. The way the Swedish state appears in the women's accounts confirms this: no participant described a state institution as the source of regular material support. The state is present only through emergency assistance under the Social Services Act, which all women described through the NGO that mediates it. The previous policy literature confirms this picture: Giritli Nygren and Nyhlén (2017) and Thorisdottir (2018) both showed that Swedish municipalities read their obligations under the Act narrowly and limit assistance to acute situations, with no entitlement to income support for those who are not permanent residents. This configuration thus carries a redistributive claim: the women's daily economic activity in Sweden and their material dependence on resources circulating in the Swedish space do not translate into any standing within the redistributive arrangement of the Swedish polity.

8.3 Recognition

Recognition concerns institutionalized patterns of cultural value, namely the patterns that constitute social actors as full partners in interactions (Fraser and Honneth, 2003). The participants live within two distinct institutionalized patterns of recognition: one inside their community of origin, and one in the Swedish public space they inhabit. Each grants recognition on different terms.

Within the community, their economic activity was folded back into the figure of the sacrificing mother, on a condition not extended to their husbands. All five women framed their work in Sweden as sacrifice for their children, and in four cases reported their husbands did not provide any income. Empirical data showed asymmetry in expectations in their male counterpart, as their husbands' lack of provision did not require justification and they were described as enjoying more freedom in Romania. The recognition the women held inside the community was therefore conditional; it rested on continued sacrifice and structured around the same maternal frame that organized their earlier domestic role.

When it came to housework back in Romania, the accounts were identical. All women used to handle all the cooking, cleaning, and childcare alone, with their partners contributing little or nothing. They never questioned this structure, and simply affirmed they genuinely enjoyed it. Migration changed only the practical organization of their daily lives, leaving their view of these roles intact.

The women had all become breadwinners, and the housework that had once been entirely their domain was delegated, out of necessity, to their partners. The asymmetry described thus concerned both an unbalanced division of housework and the freedom from being expected to provide. Maternal sacrifice itself is not the issue; what matters is the asymmetry. In all interviews, pride was always grounded in the hurdles the women were enduring to provide for their family, never in personal terms or achievements; two participants even used the same formulation "I work very hard not for me but for my children". The role asymmetry between them and their partners makes the framing maternal rather than simply parental. The women did not have any space for independent standing of their personal value. Their recognition was anchored in their continued sacrifice for the family, an expectation not mirrored in their male partner, and thus carrying a gender component.

These findings are consistent with Crowley et al.'s (2013) documentation of subordinate roles within Roma family structures. Maestri and Mantovan (2025) also found a similar pattern among Romanian Roma migrants in Italy, whose economic activity was organized around the maternal role, with the host society reading the women's presence through the same lens.

In Swedish public spaces, the same economic activity was interpreted through a cultural frame that the literature on Roma women in public space has documented in distinctively gendered terms (Talpa, 2014; Maestri and Mantovan, 2025).

All participants reported frequent verbal abuse, with content consistent in all accounts, namely the demand to find work or leave the country. The same occupation sustained the family from the women's perspective and disqualified them from the view of the public. The scope of this claim is limited by the study's design, since I have no evidence of how the Swedish public perceives them directly; further studies are needed to clarify this. Unlike the maternal frame within the community of origin, the patterns of cultural value the participants meet in such public spaces are produced in Sweden, not brought from elsewhere.

The misrecognition documented in Swedish public space is produced in Sweden itself. Read together with the maternal frame inside the community of origin, it shows that the women are denied standing as full partners in social interaction across two distinct registers, in both cases through institutionalized cultural patterns rather than isolated encounters (Fraser and Honneth, 2003).

The interviews also described encounters the women experienced as favorable, including long-standing friendships with members of the Swedish society and respectful treatment from healthcare and most law-enforcement officers. Positive experiences with some individuals do not unsettle the public encounters that the women describe as the most frequent, namely verbal abuse from members of the public. The positive material has to be weighed against the methodological limitations of the study, taken up in following chapters, and with the comparative baseline of Romania as a reference. Nonetheless, it is important to acknowledge these positive interactions, which serve as a significant validation of their dignity. These supportive networks function as an emotional counterweight, making the daily instances of street discrimination feel less heavy and more bearable.

The experience with Swedish street-level bureaucrats, such as healthcare professionals and law-enforcement officers, was overall positive. Swedish polity structurally excludes the participants through the legal void of EU free movement rules. Individual institutional actors, however, exercised administrative discretion during face-to-face encounters, granting the participants a baseline of civic respect. This contrast shows that misrecognition is not a uniform institutional practice in Gothenburg, varies depending on how street-level bureaucrats execute their roles.

The participants' accounts of healthcare workers and police officers corresponds to what the literature on street-level bureaucracy has theorized. A polity does not only take form in legislation and central administration; it also articulates through the daily encounters between individuals and the public workers who deliver services. For a person who has limited contact with the legislative or administrative apparatus, as it is the case for the participants, the polity is

encountered almost entirely at this level. The police officer who chooses to address them kindly on the street is in this sense an expression of the Swedish polity.

Lipsky defines these interactions “places where citizens experience directly the government they have implicitly constructed” (Lipsky, 2010, p. XI). The exclusion this thesis documents is legal and political, as the women hold no membership in the Swedish polity and no standing to raise claims against it. The respectful treatment by public servants occurs at a site that Lipsky (2010) interprets as the point where the polity meets those it governs. Health workers in particular were described as a source of help and consistent treatment, and most encounters with the policy were reported as civil. The Swedish state reaches the women through professionals who treat them with care, but it still withholds them from the standing that would make it an entitlement rather than a discretionary act.

This point complicates the position taken earlier in this chapter. Following Fraser (2005), I previously read the assistance the women receive as the situation of those who become objects of charity or benevolence within a polity that excludes them from the position of claimholders. The documented encounters partly contradict such a picture. For Lipsky (2010), the conduct of public-service workers at the point of delivery is not personal goodwill, but the state in the form in which most of those it governs actually meet it. The service the women receive from healthcare providers and law enforcement agents is discretionary, since it does not derive from any entitlement. Notwithstanding, it is an act carried out in the name of the Swedish state.

A note of caution applies here, however. The healthcare staff the women describe are reached through Råddningsmissionen, which has established working relationships with specific clinics and providers. The participants therefore meet a selected group of professionals who have already accepted the NGO's referrals and who work in settings where treating this population beyond emergency assistance has become routine. Their accounts cannot tell us how the participants would be received by Swedish healthcare staff without this mediation, or how the encounter would unfold in clinics outside the NGO's network. Healthcare is a more mediated interaction in the participants' case, since it is provided by a civil society organization rather than as an entitlement given by the National system, except for emergency assistance. Within the consultation itself, however, the doctor or nurse who sees them is part of the Swedish public health system, making the encounter a direct point of contact with the Swedish state.

The police encounters are different in kind, since they involve civility in public space rather than the delivery of services, and they are unmediated by any institution.

A study with health workers and law enforcement officers who work with vulnerable EU citizens in Swedish cities would clarify on what basis they extend care or civility when the legal order does not require it, and whether the discretion they hold is shaped by training, by the culture

of the institution, by personal disposition, or by lack of knowledge of the legal status of the individuals they take care of.

Similarly, to the healthcare providers, Rådningsmissionen, by contrast, is a civil society organization; the assistance it provides operates in a register of benevolence.

8.4 The Intertwining of Redistribution and Recognition

Fraser treats groups whose subordination is rooted simultaneously in the economic structure and the status order as "two-dimensional," with gender and race as paradigm cases. The two harms are primary and co-original, and addressing one dimension alone leaves the other in place (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 19).

The women in this study stand at the intersection of axes that are two-dimensional in this sense: gender, ethnicity and class position. The interview material shows how redistributive and recognitive struggles reinforce one another in their daily lives. Welfare entitlement and formal employment are both unavailable to them under the legal architecture set out in the policy chapters, and so the only earning open to them takes place in public space and through the informal economy. The economic activity that follows from this exclusion is then read by the Swedish public as the absence of work, and the women are told repeatedly to find a job or to leave the country. The reading is consistent with the position the welfare exclusion has already placed them in, since people whose presence is interpreted as a refusal to work are not perceived as having any rightful claim to social entitlement. The material exclusion produces the conditions in which the cultural reading forms, and the two are mutually reinforcing at the level of how the women's situation is interpreted in public space.

The same intertwining operates inside the community of origin, in a different shape. The women's economic role as providers gave them weight within the family, but the recognition that followed rested on continued sacrifice, with no equivalent expectation on their male counterparts. The redistributive shift from doing only housework to providing for the family produced no corresponding shift in recognition. Their new economic activity was read in the same maternal frame as the domestic role it replaced, while the husbands' lack of provision did not require justification, as they were described as enjoying more freedom in Romania. The women became the ones earning the money, but they were still recognized as mothers rather than as providers. The economic and cultural dimensions produce one another, both in Swedish public space and within the community of origin.

8.5 Representation

The redistributive and recognitive claims identified in 8.2 and 8.3 require a political community within which they can be raised. Fraser argues that "no claim for justice can avoid presupposing some notion of representation, implicit or explicit, insofar as none can avoid assuming a frame" (Fraser, 2005, p. 80). The question, then, is whether Sweden, given the legal position the participants occupy, is that frame.

The participants of the study are citizens of another EU Member State residing in Sweden beyond the three-month period of legal residence granted by Directive 2004/38/EC. Under the Keynesian-Westphalian frame, in which the territorial state is the default unit within which justice claims are raised, their standing as subjects of injustice is assigned to Romania (Fraser, 2005). Their joint subjection to Swedish governance is nonetheless concrete. They are reached by the emergency provisions of the Social Services Act, by an NGO that also provides them access to healthcare, and by daily encounters with Swedish citizens and law-enforcement that organize their public life. Their standing is assigned to one polity while their daily life unfolds under another.

The corresponding exclusion produced by this kind of mismatch is called misframing: a boundary drawn so as to deny those subject to a community's governance any share in its authorized contests over justice (Fraser, 2005). The women's situation corresponds to this criterion: the Roma inclusion strategy that would address ethnic marginalization and the welfare regime that would address material conditions both rest on the residence criterion the women cannot meet, and the criterion derives from the same Westphalian frame that excludes them. Those affected by misframing become "objects of charity or benevolence" within the polity that excludes them (Fraser, 2005, p. 77). The women in this study receive emergency assistance under the Social Services Act and a range of provisions through Rådningsmissionen, besides money given by passers-by. Within this framework, these provisions sit on a different register from claims of entitlement; they are not produced by the polity's recognition of obligation toward those it governs.

None of the claims described above can be addressed within either polity, as currently framed. The participants live between two: Romania holds their formal citizenship and the primary responsibility under the EU framework for their social inclusion, while Sweden holds their daily governance. Neither polity treats them as among those whose claims it is obliged to consider. Whether the redistributive and recognitive struggles documented here can be raised at all depends on whether, and how, either polity comes to claim responsibility for them.

8.6 Romania as a Baseline of Comparison

One theme arose inductively during the analysis, outside the initial coding frame. The women consistently used their experiences in Romania as a baseline for interpreting their situation in Sweden. I consequently added the pattern code "Suppression in Romania." The Romanian baseline is integral to how the participants understand their condition in Sweden,

As set out in section 7.3, their accounts of Romania combined material deprivation with explicit ethnic discrimination; the women linked their inability to find employment and the treatment they received directly to their Roma identity. They arrived in Sweden carrying a perspective shaped by experiences of mistreatment and economic struggle.

Romania was also the only available reference point the women possessed for evaluating their present circumstances. They had not lived in a context where formal employment and education were accessible to them or where institutional entitlements extended to people in their position. Sweden, measured against that experience, registered as an improvement. Doina and Mirela both stated explicitly that the differential treatment they had received in Romania did not occur in Sweden, and Camelia described being respected and left alone in Gothenburg in terms that drew an implicit contrast with her past. The accounts of friendliness from Swedes and respectful treatment in healthcare and most encounters with law enforcement are framed against this background rather than against any conception of the Swedish political membership.

The baseline matters for the argument made above. Standing as a subject of justice follows subjection to a governance structure rather than the subject's own recognition of standing. The participants have lived their entire lives outside any polity that treated them as equally standing subject of justice. In Romania they were systematically excluded from education, employment, and the social-support system. In Sweden they encounter the state primarily through the NGO that mediates emergency provision. They have no experiential template for a state that recognized them as full members. Their assessment of Sweden as preferable to Romania is therefore not a verdict on Swedish policy.

Table 1: Inductive Category of Coding- Distribution and Recognition

Dimension	First-cycle codes	Quotes
Distribution	Navigating Economic Survival	“If you ask all of us ladies why we moved to Sweden, we will all give the same answer: to make money for our children” “I am here for my children and to make their lives better” “Every time I need any other kind of support I come to the NGO” “Now we feel safer because we have somewhere to sleep”
	Barriers to Economic Participation	“I really wish I could work here, for example take care of older ladies, clean houses, in hotels, but I cannot because I don't speak English or Swedish” “I would really like to learn how to read and write and learn some Swedish, otherwise I cannot do almost anything” “I cannot do other jobs and I cannot stay here permanently; I have my children in Romania”
Recognition	Asserting Dignity and Agency	“How can you not be proud to be a woman? I am proud because I have children and grandchildren” “I am proud because many people treat me badly and tell me to go to work, but I still resist and I am strong” “God is always observing and listening, and he knows I am a good person” “I feel like I have power. I tell you honest, I am power”

		“When there is something important, especially regarding our children, I make decisions together with my husband” “When I go to the doctor, they always treat me with respect, and I do not think there is a difference in treatment between me and a Swedish person” “I feel like the police treat me with much respect” “Many Swedish girls are so sweet and always help me”
	Stigmatization and Constraint	“Sometimes people do not treat me with respect and tell me to go to work or go back to my country” “You have no idea how many 'slaps' I get here” “Often they ask me why I do not go to work and why I am here begging” “In Romania, I was the only one taking care of the house and cleaning and he does not do anything, but I like doing it” “There are some things I cannot do because my husband says no, like some family decisions”

Table 2: Deductive Category of Coding- Suppression in Romania

Dimension	First-cycle Codes	Quotes
Distribution	Economic Deprivation	“I wish I could go back to Romania but I would earn so little that I could not even buy diapers for children” “I was forced to move here, like many other people. It is impossible to find a job in Romania”
Recognition	Ethnic Discrimination	“In Romania, nobody can hire me because I cannot read and because I am a gypsy” “I think it is because I am a gypsy that I did not work. Especially in Romania they treat me differently because I am a gypsy. They do not like us” “In Romania they treat me differently because I am a gypsy”

8.7 Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research

The study is exploratory in scope, and its findings rest on five participants recruited through a single NGO in Gothenburg. The access this NGO made possible was the condition for reaching a highly marginalized population, but it introduced selection bias as well: the participants are women who engage with civil society support, and their experiences may differ from those who remain outside such networks.

Their constant use of Romania as a baseline, paired with their description of it as a place of serious material deprivation and discrimination, also suggests that they may not be fully aware of the welfare services and entitlements available to people in Sweden, which made it harder to capture their claims in the terms in which the Swedish polity would register them.

The study is geographically and institutionally bounded as well. Gothenburg has its own municipal interpretation of the Social Services Act and its own civil society infrastructure, and the high degree of local discretion in the governance of this population means experiences likely vary across Swedish municipalities.

My pre-existing relationship with the participants was fundamental in building trust, but it may also have shaped how they chose to present their experiences. In two of the interviews, language mediation through a Romanian-speaking social worker necessarily filtered some of the meaning I could have grasped directly had I spoken Romanian. I worked to mitigate these effects through open-ended questioning and reflexive awareness, but the co-constructed nature of qualitative data remains a constraint on the findings. Several directions for further research follow from these limitations.

Comparative work in other Swedish cities would clarify how local policy contexts and civil society infrastructure shape the experiences of this population. Research that follows the same women across several years would help, since many of them move back and forth between Sweden and Romania, and a single round of interviews captures only one moment in a life organized around mobility. Empirical work in Romania with women who have not migrated, or who have returned, would clarify whether the conditions the participants describe still hold for women who remained.

Studies that include Roma men in the same legal category would test whether the gendered pattern documented here is symmetric. The women describe an asymmetry in expectations and recognition between themselves and their husbands; whether Roma men experience a corresponding framing inside the community and in Swedish public space remains an open question.

9. Implications for Policy Debate and Conclusion

9.1 The Structural Position of the Participants

The discussion chapters showed how the redistributive, recognitive, and political dimensions are intertwined in the participants' lives. Reading these dimensions together brought into one frame the structural-legal scholarship on the "vulnerable EU citizen" category and the sociological work on Roma women, which have so far been examined in parallel.

The participants occupy three axes of disadvantage at once: gender, ethnic-minority membership, and a class position produced by exclusion from formal labor and welfare entitlements. I chose Fraser over the intersectional accounts of Crenshaw (1991) and Kóczé and Popa (2009), which also hold gender, "race", and class together, because Fraser's framework adds a third dimension, representation, which the intersectional accounts do not address. Both studies were developed for populations who already hold legal standing in a polity and ask how the community's categories fail them. The women in this study are not failed by Sweden's categories in this sense; they are excluded from being among those in relation to whom Sweden has obligations at all.

Fraser's framework is the analytical foundation of this thesis. Her account, developed with Honneth (2003), holds that axes of subordination overlap, and that maldistribution and misrecognition operate on one another rather than separately. Groups that sit at more than one axis suffer harm in which the economic and cultural sides do not operate in isolation. Her later work (Fraser, 2005) adds a third dimension, representation, which names the prior condition under which the women in this study find themselves. The all-subjected principle (Fraser, 2008) provides the criterion for assessing it. The thesis used this framework because it was developed to hold these sides in a single analysis.

The interviews extended what the literatures had so far documented. They showed the way the women describe their economic activity as work and as care, the comparison they draw between Sweden and Romania, and the maternal frame that organizes their standing both inside their community and in Swedish public space. These findings emerge from reading the two literature together through five accounts, and complement the structural account of the populations' exclusion.

On this view, the women's marginalization is not a failure inside a political community, but a question of where the community's boundaries are drawn, and it is the condition under which the claims the women's situation contains cannot be raised within any established frame.

Two EU frameworks shape the participants' position. *Directive 2004/38/EC* regulates the right of EU citizens to move and reside across the Union, granting unconditional residence for the first three months and conditioning continued lawful residence on formal employment,

sufficient resources, or student status. The participants cannot meet these conditions, since the informal activities they perform are not recognized as work and they do not possess sufficient resources. They are not deported, and their stay remains formally lawful when they engage in circular migration, but they do not acquire access to standard welfare services (Friberg et al., 2025).

The EU Roma Strategic Framework, in parallel, assigns primary responsibility for Roma social inclusion to the member state of citizenship, Romania, and Sweden's own 2012 national strategy operates within this allocation through a residence criterion (European Commission, 2020; Regeringskansliet, 2012). The participants therefore fall outside the framework designed to address Roma social inclusion because the member state primarily responsible for that inclusion is the one they left. The conditions they described as their reason for migration fall under Romania's responsibility under the EU framework, a question that lies outside the Swedish frame and the scope of this thesis.

Their subjection to Swedish governance is concrete and continuous, yet their political membership is assigned, by the logic of the EU framework, to Romania. The all-subjected principle (Fraser, 2008) makes visible the structure of this arrangement: a population subject to continuous governance in one member state while political responsibility for its social inclusion is allocated to another. The thesis uses the principle as a lens for reading the participants' position and does not take a position on whether Swedish policy should adopt it. Neither framework includes a mechanism that bears directly on the inconsistency between them.

The thesis does not read this contradiction as a fixed feature of the architecture. There is a space the EU framework leaves open, in which both Member States, Romania as the polity of citizenship and Sweden as the polity of residence, can act. The policy avenues examined in the next section concern Sweden's role within that shared space, while the conditions in Romania that produce the migration fall under Romania's parallel responsibility under the EU framework.

9.2 Policy Avenues Within the Existing EU Framework

A further consideration concerns how the policy debate itself has been framed. In Sweden, the presence of vulnerable EU citizens has been discussed predominantly through the register of migration policy (Barker, 2017; Friberg et al., 2025), but the legal condition of this population differs from other cases of international migration. They are not migrants in the conventional sense, but citizens of the European Union exercising treaty rights of free movement. Union citizenship, introduced by the Maastricht Treaty in 1992, carries the right to move and reside freely across Member States. The participants' presence in Sweden derives from this status and remains lawful as long as they engage in circular migration; they cannot be removed on the grounds that would apply to a third-country national in an irregular position (Civil Rights Defenders, 2015; Friberg et al., 2025). They hold the mobility rights of EU citizenship without the social rights it conditions on economic activity, distinguishing their position from that of a citizen of a non-EU state migrating to Sweden under similar precarity. A third-country migrant in an irregular position is excluded from welfare on grounds of unauthorized presence; this population is excluded while its presence remains formally lawful under EU law. The participants describe themselves consistently as workers and providers acting under constraint, and this self-description corresponds to the legal status they hold under EU law more closely than to the migration register through which Swedish public debate has tended to discuss them.

Within the existing legal frame, several policy avenues remain open to Sweden that do not require expanding welfare entitlements attached to formal residence. The 2021 *Council Recommendation on Roma equality, inclusion and participation*, which renews and replaces the 2013 instrument, addresses the configuration described above directly (Council of the European Union, 2021). The Recommendation confirms that the conditions for exercising free movement under *Directive 2004/38/EC* must be respected, and at the same time holds that it remains “necessary to seek to improve the living conditions of Roma and to pursue measures to promote their economic and social inclusion in their Member States of origin as well as in their Member States of residence” (recital 17). It lists EU mobile Roma among the groups whose specific vulnerabilities Member States are asked to address (recital 15), asks that equal access to quality healthcare is ensured for EU mobile Roma among other vulnerable Roma populations (paragraph 9(a)(iv)), and that income support is combined with activation measures “particularly for Roma women and EU mobile Roma” (paragraph 3(c)).

The Recommendation is paired with a funding instrument. Under the European Social Fund Plus, established by *Regulation 2021/1057*, a Specific Objective is dedicated to promoting the socio-economic integration of marginalized communities such as Roma (Regulation (EU) 2021/1057, Article 4(1)(j)).

Access to dedicated resources under this objective is conditioned on a Member State having in place a national Roma strategic framework reflecting the priorities of the EU framework. Sweden's national Roma strategic framework is the instrument within which EU mobile Roma could be recognized as a target group without altering their residence status, opening access to measures funded under this objective.

The Swedish policy debate has tended to present the choice as one between extending welfare entitlements to all EU citizens regardless of residence conditions and treating the population as a problem of migration control. The EU sources cited above already supply responses outside this opposition. Recital 17 of the 2021 Recommendation places responsibility for Roma inclusion measures on Member States of residence together with Member States of citizenship, which grounds bilateral cooperation between Sweden and Romania on the conditions that produce migration. Recital 15 and paragraphs 3(c) and 9(a)(iv) of the same instrument name EU mobile Roma as a target subgroup; Sweden can formally recognize this within its existing 2012 Roma strategy through a supplement to the government communication, without amending Swedish legislation on minorities, welfare, or migration. Article 4(1)(j) of *Regulation 2021/1057* dedicates a Specific Objective of the European Social Fund Plus to the socio-economic integration of marginalized communities such as Roma. Sweden could direct it toward language training, literacy programs, health access measures, and anti-discrimination initiatives that do not depend on residence rights. None of these responses extends residence-linked entitlements or treats the population as a problem of migration control. Their implementation remains a political question, not a legal one.

9.3 Limits of the Framework and Concluding Remarks

The conditions documented above are not the only factors shaping the participants' situation in Sweden, establishing a theoretical limit of Fraser's framework.

All women reported very low levels of formal education, with most having attended only a few years of primary school in Romania. The language barriers documented in the empirical findings follow in part from this education baseline. Even in a setting where the legal conditions for permanent residence were within reach, the path to formal employment would be conditioned by factors that lie outside the framework. These include literacy, school history, prior work, and the participants' own preference regarding the kind of life they want to lead and whether they want to enter the formal labor market, which is arguably also a cultural factor.

The maternal frame labeled as a form of misrecognition belongs to the same register. It is a pattern internal to the community of origin, and Swedish policy has no direct lever over it. Even a setting in which the legal exclusion was removed would not, on its own, dissolve the asymmetric recognition the women hold within the family. Sweden can address the dimensions that operate through its institutions, namely the welfare exclusion, the public-space encounters, and the residence criterion. The cultural pattern that organizes the women's standing inside their own community remains the work of that community itself. The choice of asking the women some questions about their division of housework in Romania was driven by my interest in hearing about their conception of gender roles, from which I derived considerations regarding how they are valued in the family.

I do not propose the all-subjected principle as a policy prescription. The framework was used here as a diagnostic, not as a normative claim either polity ought to act on. The policy implications that follow require a combination of EU, Swedish, and Romanian levers, a political question that the documentation of five women's accounts cannot answer.

The contribution this thesis offers is the voice of individuals who live the consequences of being placed between two polities. They hold the formal citizenship of one and the daily governance of the other, without holding the social rights either polity attached to its members. Their accounts press claims for redistribution and recognition that neither frame, as currently drawn, leaves room to register.

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Appendix

Table 3:

The three dimensions of justice in Fraser and Honneth (2003) and their corresponding forms of injustice

Dimension	Form of Injustice
Distribution (Economic dimension)	Maldistribution Injustice rooted in the economic structure of society (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 17) Exploitation Having the fruits of one's labor appropriated for the benefit of others" (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13) Economic Marginalization Being confined to undesirable or poorly-paid work or being denied access to income generating labor altogether (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13) Deprivation Being denied an adequate material standard of living (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13)
Recognition (Cultural dimension)	Misrecognition Injustices rooted in the status order of society and traceable to the society's institutionalized patterns of cultural value (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, pp.17-18)

	Cultural domination: Being subjected to patterns of interpretation and communication that are associated with another culture and are alien and/or hostile to one's own (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13) Nonrecognition: Being rendered invisible via the authoritative representational, communicative, and interpretative practices of one's own culture" (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13) Disrespect: Being routinely maligned or disparaged in stereotypic public cultural representations and/or in everyday life interactions" (Fraser and Honneth, 2003, p. 13)
Representation (Political dimension)	Misrepresentation: Injustices concerning the boundaries of the political community and the rules of decision making (Fraser, 2005, p. 75). It includes: - Ordinary-political misrepresentation: It occurs when political decision rules wrongly deny some of the included full participation as peers in political contests (Fraser, 2005, p. 76)

	- Misframing: It occurs when the community's boundaries are drawn in such a way to wrongly exclude some people from the chance to participate at all in its authorized contests over justice (Fraser, 2005, p. 77)
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Table 4:

First-cycle inductive codes from the interview material on the participants' current life in Sweden, organized by pattern theme under the headings of Redistribution and Recognition, with representative verbatim quotes.

Redistribution

Pattern Theme: Navigating Economic Survival

First Cycle Code	Verbatim Quotes
Economic Motivation for Migrating Participant describes migration as a deliberate choice driven by the need to support children and family.	"I am here for my children and to make their lives better. I work because I want to give them more opportunities in the future." (Camelia) "I just want to make enough money to buy my children a pen, maybe a book." (Maria) "If you ask all of us ladies why we moved to Sweden, we will all give the same answer: to make money for our children." (Mirela) "I decided to come here because people from here are very good and help us. I decided to do it myself because I wanted to make money to take better care of my children and pay for light and water in Romania." (Doina)
Participant frames selling self-published books as respectable labour and describes begging as an unwanted	"My work is to sell my books to people. I do not beg. I don't like to sit down." (Elena)

necessity accompanied by sadness or shame.	"I cannot sell books everyday. I only sell books and I don't beg. People do not buy many books and now I don't really sell." (Camelia) "I have never thought to do a different work and I like selling my books a lot. I like talking to people and meeting new people." (Elena) "Begging is no work; it is only sad. I do not like it, but I need it because I do not have any other situation." (Mirela) "Do you think I want to sit here everyday? No, people constantly tell me to go to work." (Maria)
Active Use of NGOs Participant describes proactively seeking and receiving material aid from civil society organizations.	"Every time I need any other kind of support I come to the NGO and ask them for anything." (Doina) "When I need help in general, I always come to the NGO and ask Sofia or Christian." (Camelia) "Now we feel safer because we have somewhere to sleep." (Mirela) "Whenever I need other things I come to the shelter, for example if I need medicine, clothes, bureaucratic aid." (Elena) "If I need any other kind of help, I just come to the NGO and I get everything I need." (Mirela)

Sending Remittances Participant sends a portion of her income to family members in Romania.	"What keeps me going in Sweden is the money I get from my job, which I can send to my children." (Camelia) "All the money I make, I give to my children in Romania." (Mirela) "If I make 200 SEK, I keep 100 for me to buy food and cigarettes and I send 100 to Romania." (Doina) "Here it is easier because I get things for my children from people or from the NGO and then I send it to my grandchildren in Romania." (Camelia)
Low Income Participant reports daily earnings insufficient to meet basic needs.	"I barely make thirty to fifty SEK per day." (Camelia) "I make thirty to fifty SEK per day." (Maria) "With the money I make (200 SEK per day), I can't send it all home because I also have to make a living in Sweden and buy food and cigarettes." (Doina)

Pattern Theme: Barriers to Economic Participation

First Cycle Code	Verbatim Quotes
Language Barrier Lack of Swedish or English proficiency as an obstacle to formal employment.	"If I only could speak English and Swedish, I would certainly look for a job and I would work, but I don't know any of them." (Doina) "I really wish I could work here, for example take care of

	older people, clean houses, in hotels, but I cannot because I don't speak English or Swedish." (Maria)
Illiteracy Inability to read or write as an obstacle to employment or service access.	"I would really like to learn how to read and write and learn some Swedish, otherwise I cannot do almost anything." (Maria)
Legal Status as Barrier Precarious legal status as a vulnerable EU citizen constrains work options or length of stay.	"I cannot do other jobs and I cannot stay here permanently; I have my children in Romania." (Mirela) (Elena also referred to having to go back and forth from Romania to Sweden to have the right to stay.)

Recognition

Pattern Theme: Asserting Dignity and Agency

First Cycle Code	Verbatim Quotes
Pride as Woman/Worker/Mother Expression of pride in identity as a woman, mother, grandmother, or provider.	"How can you not be proud to be a woman? I am proud because I have children and grandchildren." (Doina) "I feel proud as a woman, and I am strong. I work very hard not for me but for my children." (Mirela) "I feel proud as a woman and I am strong. I work very hard not for me but for my children." (Camelia) "I am proud because many people treat me badly and tell me to go to work, but I still resist and I am strong."

	(Maria) "I do feel proud as a woman." (Elena) "Yes, I am so proud to be a woman. I take care of my children and grandchildren and take them everywhere. I work hard for them." (Mirela) "I am proud of myself. For me it is very hard but I don't want to give up." (Mirela) "I am very poor and my husband is sick and he was operated and cannot work. I came here to make money so I can also take him to the doctor." (Camelia)
Agency in Migration Decision and in Family Decisions Participant states that she made the decision to come to Sweden herself, either alone or jointly, and describes exercising agency in family decisions, including explicit	"I decided myself to come to Sweden." (Elena) "I decided alone to come to Sweden." (Camelia) "It was only me who decided to come to Sweden." (Maria) "My husband and I decided together that I should come to Sweden." (Mirela) "When there is something important, especially regarding our children, we make decisions together." (Elena) "We always make choice together; whatever happens, we talk." (Camelia)

	"If I make more money, I share it with my husband; this is called 'tradiciona' in Romanian." (Mirela) "I feel like I have power. I tell you honest, I am power." (Mirela)
Faith as Moral Compass Participant references God or religious faith as a source of strength or moral guidance.	"God is always observing and listening, and he knows I am a good person." (Maria) "I always trust God because he has a plan and he is good." (Mirela) "I will tell you one fact: yesterday I only made 20 crowns begging. Later, I met another poor, young girl and she asked me for money for her daughter. I immediately gave her all the 20 crowns." (Maria)
Respect from the Public Participant reports kind or respectful treatment from members of the Swedish public.	"It never happens that people treat me badly because everyone knows me on the streets, and they say 'Hej Hej' and respect me." (Camelia) "I like my life here and there are some very good people in this country and it is very calm." (Elena) "When people get their salary, they always give me money and then they give me food, furniture, and stuff to send to my children." (Camelia) "Everyone gives me something. It is not much, like 200,

	300, 150 SEK, so I can pay for bills and send some things to my children." (Mirela)
Cultivating Relationships with Swedish People Participant describes ongoing supportive relationships with specific Swedish individuals.	"I have many Swedish girls that are so sweet and always help me. We have a WhatsApp group together." (Mirela) "There are many Swedish people I have known for years and every time they see me, they yell my name and come hug me." (Maria) "When I sell my books on the streets, many people stop by and are interested in our story. They don't always buy books, but I am happy they get to know how we live in Romania." (Elena) "I am so thankful to this country and to the people who live here. They help me a lot." (Camelia)
Positive Healthcare Experience Participant reports respectful treatment during encounters with the Swedish healthcare system.	"I needed to see a doctor in the past and it was very nice. He treated me very well." (Elena) "When I go to the doctor, they always treat me with respect, and I do not think there is a difference in treatment between me and a Swedish person." (Maria) "Doctors here are way better than in Romania; they talk very well and treat me with respect." (Maria) "When I ask for help for example at the doctor office, I feel treated well." (Elena)

Respect from Law Enforcement Bodies Participant reports respectful treatment by law enforcement bodies	"I feel like the police treat me with much respect." (Elena) "I do not have any problems with the police." (Doina) "The police never treats me badly." (Mirela) "Only two times the police treated me aggressively, many years ago. They took me to a cage for three hours; it was only short, and they asked me why I had stolen food. Once I told them I was hungry and did not have any money, they let me out and understood me." (Mirela) "Regarding the police and authorities, they never treat me badly." (Mirela)
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Pattern Theme: Experiences of Stigmatization and Constraint

First Cycle Code	Verbatim Quotes
Verbal Abuse from the Public Participant reports hostile or disrespectful remarks from members of the public.	"Sometimes people do not treat me with respect and tell me to go to work or go back to my country." (Elena) "Often they ask me why I do not go to work and why I am here begging." (Mirela) "You have no idea how many 'slaps' I get here." (Maria)

	"It happens sometimes that they do not treat me well and say bad words." (Doina)
Aggression from Law Enforcement bodies Participant reports aggressive or unfair treatment by law enforcement bodies	"The guards at the mall are really bad. They are very aggressive." (Elena) "Once the guards forbid us to show up for twenty four hours. When I came back, even though I was not selling books, they took us out again." (Elena) "The ones that bother me are the guards." (Doina) "There are two guards in the mall that are really rude. Next time I see them, I will take a picture so I can show you." (Elena) "Police? they always tell me 'go, go, go', everyday." (Maria, who did not distinguish police from guards)
Unbalanced Housework as Standard Participant describes doing all or most household and childcare labour in Romania with little contribution from her male partner.	"In Romania, I was the only one taking care of the house and cleaning and he does not do anything, but I like doing it." (Elena) "When I was home in Romania, I used to do every housework: make food for the children, take them to school, help them with homework, take them everywhere, also my grandchildren." (Doina) "I used to be the only one taking care of the house

	together with the girls." (Camelia) "When I was living there with him, I was the only one taking care of the house, cleaning, and cooking." (Maria) "It was usually only me and my husband's mother who took care of the house." (Mirela)
Lack of Agency Participant states that her husband's disapproval prevents her from making certain decisions.	"There are some things I cannot do because my husband says no, like some family decisions." (Maria)

Pattern Theme: Suppression in Romania

First Cycle Codes	Verbatim Quote
Economic Deprivation Participant describes severe material hardship and lack of viable income in Romania.	"I wish I could go back to Romania but I would earn so little that I could not even buy diapers for children." (Camelia) "I was forced to move here, like many other people. It is impossible to find a job in Romania." (Maria) (Doina described child allowance and social assistance together as five hundred SEK per month, insufficient for even a pack of diapers and some milk.)

Ethnic Discrimination Participant links her inability to find work or poor treatment in Romania to her Roma identity.	In Romania, nobody can hire me because I cannot read and because I am a gypsy." (Doina) "I think it is absolutely because I am a gypsy that I do not work. Especially in Romania they treat me differently because I am a gypsy. They do not like us." (Doina) "In Romania they treat me differently because I am a gypsy." (Mirela)
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Table 5:

Condensed overview of all first-cycle codes, organized under Fraser and Honneth's (2003) categories of Redistribution and Recognition together with the inductively derived category of Suppression in Romania. Each code is marked according to Miles et al.'s (2014) code-type classification: D (descriptive), E (emotional), V (values).

REDISTRIBUTION	Navigating Economic Survival	- Economic motivation for migrating (D, V) - Selling books as dignified work and begging as last resort (D, V, E) - Active use of NGOs (D) - Sending Remittances (D) - Low Income (D)
	Barriers to Economic Participation	- Language barrier (D) - Illiteracy (D) - Legal status as barrier (D)
RECOGNITION	Asserting Dignity and Agency	- Pride as woman/worker/provider (E, V) - Agency in migration decision and in family decisions (D, V, E) - Faith as moral compass (V)

		- Respect from the public (E, D) - Cultivating relationships with Swedish people (D) - Positive healthcare experience (E, D) - Respect from Law Enforcement Bodies (D)
	Experiences of Stigmatization and Constraint	- Verbal abuse from the public (E, D) - Aggression from Law Enforcement Bodies (D) - Unbalanced housework as standard (D) - Lack of agency (D)
SUPPRESSION IN ROMANIA	- Economic deprivation (D) - Ethnic discrimination (D, V) - Romania as a baseline of hardship (V, D)	

The interviews were conducted as open-ended, conversational exchanges rather than a fixed question-by-question survey. The following themes and example questions served as a flexible guide to ensure that all relevant topics were covered, allowing the women to speak freely about their experiences. The wording, order, and depth of questions varied according to each woman's responses and the natural flow of the conversation. Often they answered my questions even before asking.

Theme 1: Background and family situation

- Can you tell me where you are from and how long you have been in Sweden?
- Is this your first time here, or have you travelled back and forth? How many times?
- What brought you to Sweden? Who decided that you would come?
- Have you lived in any other countries before?
- Do you have children? Where do they live? how old are they?
- Where do you sleep when you are in Sweden? Do you always stay in the same place?
- Do you have a husband? Is he here with you, or does he live in your home country?

Theme 2: Daily life, work and income

- What do you usually do during the day when you are in Sweden?
- Do you have a husband? Does he live here and what does he do during the day?
- Do you see what you do as work?
- Do you see begging as work?
- How do you get money to buy food and to support your family?
- Are there things that only you do, or only your husband does? For example, taking care of the house, working outside the family?
- Who makes the important decisions in your family?
- Are you happy with what you do here? Why or why not? Would you rather do something else?

- **Theme 3: Gender dimension**

- When you were living in Romania, who took care of the house? Who took care of the children?
- What roles do you think you have as a woman?
- Are you proud to be a woman? What makes you proud?

- **Theme 4: Access to services and encounters with institutions**

- Have you ever needed to see a doctor in Sweden? Did you see one? How did that happen?
- What problems did you face when you first arrived in Sweden and needed help?
- Have you needed other types of support? What kind of support?
- When you receive support, do people treat you with respect? Can you tell me about a time when you did not feel treated with respect?
- Do you feel that Swedish people in general treat you with respect? When do you feel that, and when do you not?
- When you ask for help in the city, for example at a doctor's office, do you feel treated well?
- Have you ever felt that authorities, such as the police or guards, did not treat you well?
- Do you feel safe in Gothenburg, or do you sometimes feel afraid because of who you are?

- **Theme 5: Aspirations and future**

- What would you change in Gothenburg if you could?
- Do you have hope for your future here in Gothenburg?
- Would you like to stay in Sweden forever, or do you see yourself returning to Romania?
- What would help you the most right now?

